

Tempeh potato hash

Many taste sensations will travel through your mouth with each bite of this **bold** dish: sweet, sour, spicy, savory, and hot. It is a somewhat busy recipe, but put your mind at ease by setting yourself up with a lot of prep space and you'll sail right through it. Use Mexican oregano here, if you have it, as its more assertive flavor works nicely in concert with the other strong ingredients. Serve with eggs or rice and a salad. This hash also makes an excellent stuffing for bell peppers or acorn or delicata squash.

NOTE A large nonstick skillet with a lid works well for this dish. It will allow the tempeh to brown without sticking, which it tends to do when grated or crumbled, even with oil, in a regular pan.

About ¼ ounce dried shiitake or porcini mushrooms [7g]

1 chipotle chile, stemmed, cracked open, seeds removed

6 plum tomatoes, cut in half

3 tablespoons olive oil

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, crumbled or shredded [250g]

1 medium white onion, chopped

1 small fennel bulb (about 6 ounces), cut into small dice [180g]

1 tablespoon dried oregano, preferably Mexican

4 small red potatoes, scrubbed and cut into small cubes

½ pound cremini mushrooms, thinly sliced [250g]

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

½ teaspoon salt

Sprigs of cilantro, for garnish

- 1. Preheat** the broiler with the rack set 4 to 6 inches [10 to 15cm] from the heat. In a medium bowl, soak the dried mushrooms and chipotle chile in 2 cups [500ml] hot water until soft, 30 to 45 minutes. Strain and reserve the soaking liquid. Coarsely chop the mushrooms; mince the chile.
- 2.** Set the tomatoes, cut side down, on a baking sheet. **Broil** until the skins are cracked and lightly charred, 5 to 7 minutes. Let cool, then peel and coarsely chop the tomatoes, saving their juices.

3. In a large nonstick skillet, **heat** 2 tablespoons of the olive oil over medium-high heat. Add the tempeh and cook, stirring often, until golden brown, about 5 minutes. Remove from the pan and set aside.
4. Heat the remaining oil in the same skillet over medium heat. **Add** the onion and fennel and cook until soft and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes. Stir in the oregano and let cook for a few seconds, until fragrant. Add the potatoes, cremini mushrooms, and chopped dried mushrooms and chipotle chile. Cook until the fresh mushrooms are soft.
5. **Add** the tempeh, the tomatoes with their juices, and the salt to the skillet. Raise the heat to medium-high and cook until the liquid in the pan has evaporated. Add 1 cup [250ml] of the reserved soaking liquid.
6. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, cover, and cook, stirring occasionally, for 15 minutes, or until the potatoes are tender and most of the liquid is absorbed. Season with additional salt or more chiles, if desired. **Serve** hot, garnished with cilantro.

SERVES 4 TO 6

note The recipe calls for 1 dried chipotle chile. This works well, though I feel it only reaches the middle ground for full-on chile flavor. For a more in-depth flavor, use a combination of chiles, such as pasilla negro, ancho, and guajillo. You certainly won't use a whole one of each, but just a piece. (Start with a small amount, then add more as you see fit.) Remember to crack open the chiles first and remove excess seeds before soaking. When the chiles are soft, chop into a pulp. If you're ambitious, soak several, chop them, and use them in hummus or in other spreads, soups, or dips. Seal well and freeze what you can't use in a week.